

Narrative Structure in Film

What It Has to Do with a Portfolio Spread

*An editor and a portfolio designer are doing the same job:
take a huge amount of work and boil it down to a few moments that matter.*



Why Today Matters

You already know the Five Principles for reading a portfolio's narrative. Before we start applying them, let's borrow a trick from a field that has been solving this exact problem for a hundred years: film editing. A trailer editor never shows you the whole movie. They pick the smallest number of images that build the most tension.

- 1 Start seeing narrative as a curation problem, not a writing problem**
- 2 Understand why leaving things out builds tension instead of confusion**
- 3 Learn to judge a sequence by what it cuts, not just what it keeps**
- 4 Get a shared vocabulary for talking about pacing in your own spreads**

The Editor's Real Job

A trailer is not a summary. It's mostly a montage: different shots pulled from across the film and put back together so they suggest a story without actually telling it.

There's actually a theory behind this. Psychologist George Loewenstein calls it the **Information Gap Theory**. Here's the idea: curiosity doesn't feel good, it feels like discomfort. The moment you notice a gap between what you know and what you want to know, your brain wants to close it.

A trailer opens that gap on purpose. It shows you the world and the stakes, then holds back whatever would close the gap.

That's a curation decision before it's ever a writing decision. It's the same thing Category II had you practicing two weeks ago.

THE PEAK-END RULE

Kahneman's finding

We don't remember an experience as a whole. We remember its peak, and how it ended.

Peak

The single most intense moment in the trailer

End

The very last thing you see or hear before the title card

Everything else

Barely registers in how the trailer is remembered

Play & Discuss: The Best Case

Entertainment press had already written this film off as a dry legal drama about website coding. So the trailer couldn't sell the plot. It had to sell a feeling instead.

It opens with fifty seconds of no footage from the film at all. Just an ordinary montage of Facebook wall posts and photos, set to a haunting choral cover of Radiohead's "Creep." Only when the song swells does it finally cut into the movie's fast dialogue.

DISCUSS

- Why spend fifty seconds showing nothing from the movie itself?
- If it's not selling the story, what is this trailer actually selling?
- What's the portfolio version of leading with mood before evidence?



SELLS THE MOOD, NOT THE PLOT

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2RB3edZyeYw>

Play & Discuss: The Worst Case

The second trailer gave away the film's biggest twist. John Connor, humanity's savior, turns out to be the villain, and audiences knew that months before the movie even came out.

By the Peak-End Rule, that reveal was the trailer's peak. But it happened in the middle of a two minute YouTube video, not at the end of a two hour movie. The peak was already spent. There was nothing left to end on.

DISCUSS

- What did the editors choose to reveal, and why might they have made that call?
- Where did the trailer's own "peak" end up, and what was left for the ending?
- What's the portfolio equivalent of a spread that gives away the ending too soon?



DISCLOSES THE TWIST

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jNU_jrPxs-0

Same Craft, Opposite Choice

	The Social Network (2010)	Terminator Genisys (2015)
What's shown	50 seconds of Facebook posts. No film footage.	The film's biggest twist, stated outright.
What's withheld	The plot, the dialogue, the courtroom drama	Nothing. The ending is already known
Where the "peak" lands	Held back for the theater	Spent in the trailer itself
Trust in the audience	Total. It lets a mood do the selling	None. It assumes they need to be told

Where the Metaphor Ends

A trailer builds toward its peak, then cuts away right before it happens. You only get the payoff if you buy a ticket later.

A portfolio builds toward its peak too, but then it actually delivers. There's no later. The reviewer is judging what's in front of them right now.

That's not the metaphor breaking down. It's just the one place it stops working, and your own **Closure** principle already told you that.

CARRIES OVER

Sequencing and pacing

What process work to cut

Building tension before the resolution

DOESN'T CARRY OVER

The ending itself. Always show it.

Your sequence of images is your trailer for the project.

Every image you include is a decision about what tension to build, and what to hold back, right up until the moment you deliver the result.

NEXT · FIVE PRINCIPLES OF NARRATIVE

Focus, Structure, Curation, Lens, Closure. How professional portfolios use the same discipline.